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[GS PAPER I – GEOGRAPHY GS PAPER III – INDIAN ECONOMY] | **Publication Date: 09/09/2026**

Freight corridors



Explore India's Dedicated Freight Corridors and understand how dedicated rail infrastructure enables faster freight movement, efficient logistics and reduced transportation costs. Learn about their routes, significance, economic impact and role in strengthening India's supply-chain and infrastructure network.

FREIGHT CORRIDORS IN INDIA

Transforming India's Logistics and Transport Infrastructure

Syllabus areas:

GS Paper I – Geography

GS Paper III – Indian Economy

Why in the news?

On **8 September 2026**, Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the **final three sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor (WDFC)** in Gujarat–Maharashtra. These sections cover **326 km** and complete the entire **1,506-km WDFC from Dadri to JNPT**. It is the 2nd major operational Dedicated Freight Corridor in India — the Western DFC (WDFC). The first one is Easternal.

India's principal DFC network comprises major corridors.

A. Eastern Dedicated Freight Corridor — EDFC

Route: Ludhiana !' Sonnagal**Length:** approximately **1,337 km**

It primarily serves the movement of heavy freight associated with sectors such as **coal, steel and other industries**, connecting northern hinterlands with the eastern industrial belt.

B. Western Dedicated Freight Corridor — WDFC

Route: Dadri !' Jawaharlal Nehru Port (JNPT)**Length:** approximately **1,506 km**

It connects the northern hinterland with important industrial regions of western India and provides connectivity towards **JNPT**, an important container port.

The combined length of the two corridors is approximately **2,843 km**.

Additional corridors: proposed/planned and at different stages of DPR/preparation.

1. **East Coast DFC** — Kharagpur–Vijayawada — **proposed/DPR stage**.
2. **East–West DFC** — Palghar–Dankuni and associated sections — **proposed/DPR stage**.
3. **North–South DFC** — Vijayawada–Nagpur–Itarsi (with further proposed extension) — **pr oposed/DPR stage**.
4. **Dankuni–Surat DFC** — announced in **Union Budget 2026**; DPR preparation/updating is underway.

PM Modi described the dedicated freight corridor as the lifeline of a rapidly developing nation and also noted that India's economic transformation was accelerating due to the modern freight structure.

Earlier, passenger and goods trains were forced to run on the same tracks, which severely hampered both passenger travel and freight movement, but the dedicated corridor altered that dynamic.

1. what is Freight corridor?

The movement of goods is the backbone of a modern economy. Raw materials have to move from mines and farms to factories, manufactured goods have to reach markets, and export commodities have to reach ports. Therefore, **efficient freight transportation is essential for economic growth, industrialisation and international trade.**

"India's freight transport is multimodal—road, rail, waterways and air—while Dedicated Freight Corridors specifically refer to dedicated railway infrastructure for freight movement."

India has traditionally depended heavily on both road and rail networks for freight movement. However, conventional railway routes carry both passenger and freight trains. This creates congestion and limits the speed, capacity and reliability of goods transportation.

To address this problem, India has developed **Dedicated Freight Corridors (DFCs)**—special railway corridors designed primarily for the efficient movement of freight.

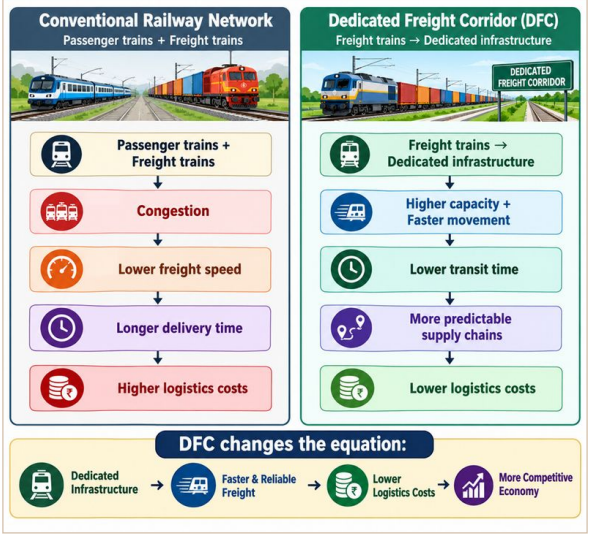
For roads, India has **Economic Corridors, National Corridors, Inter-Corridors and Feeder Routes**, mainly developed under **Bharatmala Pariyojana**.

2. Why Does India Need Freight Corridors?

India has one of the world's largest railway networks, but its conventional routes face heavy utilisation because passenger and freight trains share the same infrastructure.

A goods train may have to wait for passenger trains to pass, reducing its average speed and increasing transportation time.

The basic problem can be understood as:



Modes of Freight Transportation in India

1. **Road Freight:** Trucks and road networks are the most flexible mode for transporting goods, especially for short

and medium distances.

2. **Rail Freight:** Railways are suitable for transporting large quantities of bulk goods over long distances at relatively lower costs.

3. **Dedicated Freight Corridors (DFCs):** Special railway corridors such as the Eastern and Western DFCs improve the speed and capacity of freight movement.

4. **Water Freight:** Inland waterways and coastal shipping are economical for transporting heavy and bulky commodities over long distances.

5. **National Waterways:** India uses designated waterways to facilitate inland freight movement through rivers and canals.

6. **Coastal Shipping:** Goods can be transported between Indian ports along the country's coastline.

7. **Air Freight:** Air cargo is mainly used for high-value, perishable and time-sensitive commodities because of its speed.

8. **Multimodal Freight:** Goods may move through a combination of road, rail, waterways and air during a single supply chain.

9. **Road–Rail Integration:** Trucks can transport goods to and from railway terminals, while trains handle the long-distance movement.

10. **Port Connectivity:** Roads and railways connect production centres and logistics hubs with major ports for international trade.

11. **Logistics Parks and Terminals:** These facilities enable storage, handling, consolidation and transfer of freight between different modes.

12. **Economic Corridors:** Road-based economic corridors improve connectivity between production centres, markets, ports and consumption centres.

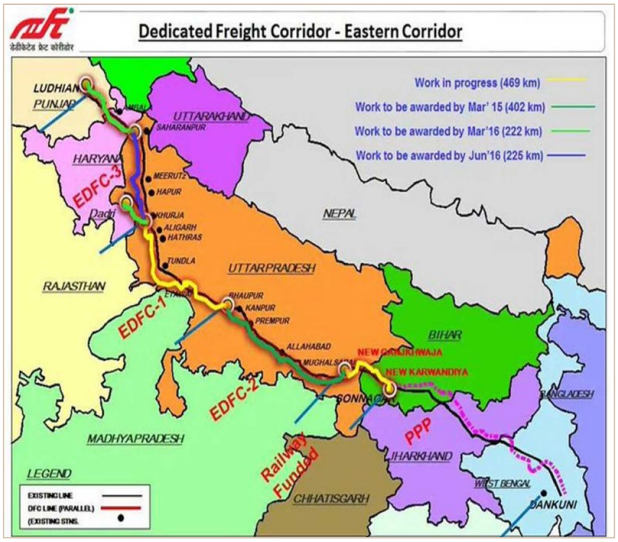
13. **Freight Networks:** Together, these modes form an integrated network connecting agriculture, mining, manufacturing and markets.

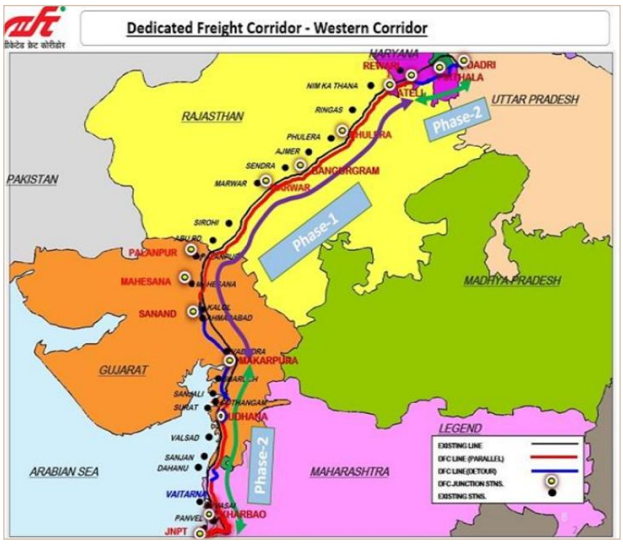
14. **Balanced Modal Mix:** Greater use of rail and waterways can reduce pressure on roads, fuel consumption, congestion and logistics costs.

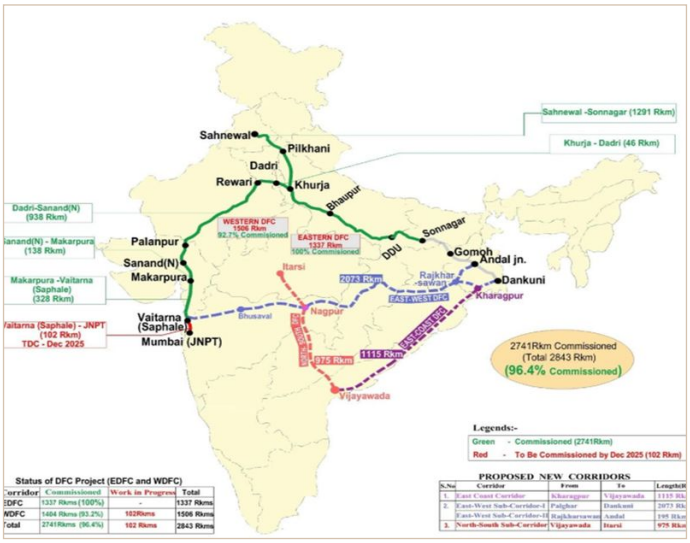
15. **Way Forward:** India's freight system is moving towards **multimodal, integrated and technology-driven logistics** for faster and more efficient movement of goods.

Freight corridor vs dedicated freight corridor:

Basis	Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC)	Freight Corridor
1. Meaning	Specially created **primarily for freight movement**	A route/network used for **movement of goods**
2. Modes	In India, specifically **railway**	Can involve **road, rail, water or air**
3.**Infrastructure**	Special, high-capacity freight infrastructure	May use **existing or upgraded infrastructure**
4. Traffic	Freight movement is **separated from regular passenger railway traffic**	Freight may share infrastructure with passenger/ other traffic
5. Examples	**Eastern DFC, Western DFC**	**Road economic corridors, railway freight routes, waterways, air-cargo networks**


Dedicated Freight Corridor - Eastern Corridor
Work in progress (469 km)
Work to be awarded by Mar' 15 (402 km)
Work to be awarded by Mar'16 (222 km)
Work to be awarded by Jun'16 (225 km)
LUDHIANA
PUNJAB
UTTARAKHAND
SAHARANPUR
HARYANA
EDFC-3
MEERUT
HAPUR
Delhi
KHURJA
ALIGARH
HATHRAS
TUNDLA
NEPAL
UTTAR PRADESH
RAJASTHAN
EDFC-1
RHAUPUR
KANPUR
PREMPUR
BIHAR
ALLAHABAD
MUGHALSARAI
NEW GHAZIPUR
NEW KARWANDIYA
EDFC-2
SONNAGAR
BANGLADESH
PPP
MADHYA PRADESH
Railway Funded
JHARKHAND
WEST BENGAL
CHHATISGARH
BANKUNI
LEGEND
EXISTING LINE
DFC LINE (PARALLEL)
(EXISTING STNS.


Dedicated Freight Corridor - Western Corridor
HARYANA
REWARI
DADRI
PALWAL
NIM KA THANA
ALWAR
RINGAS
UTTAR PRADESH
Phase-2
PHULERA
KHURJA
AJMER
SENDRA
RAJASTHAN
RANGRINGRAM
PAKISTAN
MARWAR
KHARWAR
SIROHI
ABU RD
PALANPUR
Phase-1
MAHESANA
MADHYA PRADESH
SANAND
GUJARAT
MAKARPURA
SABARMATI
SANKHEDA
SURAT
DHAKA
VALSAD
SANJAN
DAHANU
LEGEND
EXISTING LINE
DFC LINE (PARALLEL)
DFC LINE (EXTOUR)
DFC JUNCTION STNS.
EXISTING STNS.
ARABIAN SEA
Phase-2
MAHARASHTRA
VAITARNA
PANVEL
KHARBAO
JNPT


Sahnewal -Sonnagar (1291 Rkm)
Khurja - Dadri (46 Rkm)
Sahnewal
Pilkhani
Dadri
Rewari
Khurja
Bhaupur
Dadri-Sanand(N) (938 Rkm)
WESTERN DFC 1506 Rkm 92.7% Commisioned
EASTERN DFC 1337 Rkm 100% Commisioned
Palanpur
Sonnagar
DDU
Gomoh
Andal jn.
Sanand(N)
Makarpura
Itarsi
2073 Rkm
Rajkhar
Sawai
Dankuni
Makarpura -Vaitarna (Saphale) (328 Rkm)
EAST-WEST DFC
Kharagpur
Bhusaval
Nagpur
Vaitarna (Saphale) - JNPT (102 Rkm) TDC - Dec 2025
Vaitarna (Saphale)
Mumbai (JNPT)
975 Rkm
1115 Rkm
2741Rkm Commissioned (Total 2843 Rkm) (96.4% Commissioned)
Vijayawada
Legends:-
Green - Commissioned (2741Rkm)
Red - To Be Commissioned by Dec 2025 (102 Rkm)
Status of DFC Project (EDFC and WDFC)
PROPOSED NEW CORRIDORS